

Incident Response & Investigation Journal

Reusable Analyst Documentation Template

Purpose

This journal provides a consistent structure for documenting cybersecurity incidents and investigations. Each entry records the evidence reviewed, tools and data sources used, investigative findings, analyst decisions, and any required follow-up or escalation so that work can be understood, continued, and reviewed over time.

Date	Entry #	Incident / Case ID	Severity	Status
October 6, 2026	1	SIM-IR-001	High	Escalated

Entry Title

Ransomware Incident at a Health Care Clinic

Description

A small U.S. health care clinic experienced a ransomware incident that prevented employees from accessing critical files, including medical records, and disrupted normal business operations. The investigation identified targeted phishing emails containing a malicious attachment as the initial access method.

NIST Incident Response Phase

Detection and Analysis — The incident had already been detected through employee reports and the ransom note. The available information was reviewed to determine what occurred, how the attackers gained access, and the impact on the organization.

Tool(s) and Data Sources Used

Tools: None specified in the activity.

Data sources: Employee reports, ransom note, phishing email details, and the incident scenario.

The 5 W's

- **Who:** An organized group of threat actors known to target organizations in the health care and transportation industries.
- **What:** The attackers gained network access through phishing, deployed ransomware, encrypted critical files, and demanded payment in exchange for a decryption key.
- **When:** Tuesday morning at approximately 9:00 a.m.
- **Where:** A small U.S. health care clinic specializing in primary-care services.
- **Why / How:** Targeted phishing emails containing a malicious attachment were sent to employees. After the attachment was downloaded, malware was installed and the attackers gained access to the network.

Evidence and Findings

Employees reported that they could no longer access files or software required for their work. A ransom note stated that company files had been encrypted and demanded payment for the decryption key. The scenario identified targeted phishing emails with a malicious attachment as the initial access method, followed by malware installation and ransomware deployment.

Actions and Decisions

The incident was documented as a ransomware attack originating from a phishing compromise. Because critical files became inaccessible and business operations were disrupted, the organization shut down its computer systems and contacted outside organizations for reporting and technical assistance.

Next Steps / Escalation

Further incident response should determine the full scope of affected systems, preserve relevant evidence, contain the compromise, and support secure recovery of critical data. Follow-up should also address the phishing method used to gain initial access and reduce the likelihood of recurrence.

Additional Notes

The incident demonstrates how a single successful phishing attempt can create organization-wide operational impact when it leads to ransomware deployment. Maintaining clear incident documentation helps preserve the sequence of events, supporting evidence, and outstanding response needs as the investigation continues.

Date	Entry #	Incident / Case ID	Severity	Status
October 7, 2026	2	SIM-IR-002	High	Confirmed Malicious

Entry Title

Suspicious File Hash Investigation

Description

A suspicious file hash was investigated using VirusTotal to determine whether the file was malicious. The analysis reviewed vendor detections and related threat intelligence, confirming the file as Flagpro malware and identifying additional indicators of compromise associated with its activity.

NIST Incident Response Phase

Detection and Analysis — The suspicious file was analyzed to determine whether it represented a legitimate security threat. Evidence from multiple security vendors and associated indicators was reviewed to classify the file and better understand its behavior.

Tool(s) and Data Sources Used

Tools: VirusTotal

Data sources: VirusTotal Detection, Details, Relations, and Behavior data; vendor analysis; sandbox reports; file hashes; domain and IP information; network behavior.

The 5 W's

- **Who:** The file was identified as Flagpro malware, which has been commonly associated with the advanced threat actor BlackTech.
- **What:** A suspicious file hash was investigated and confirmed as malicious after more than 50 security vendors detected the file as malware.
- **When:** The activity did not provide a specific incident date or time.
- **Where:** The investigation was performed using VirusTotal. Related network activity included the domain `org.misecure.com` and IP address `207.148.109.242`.
- **Why / How:** Vendor detections, file information, behavioral data, and associated indicators showed that the file exhibited malicious activity consistent with Flagpro malware.

Evidence and Findings

VirusTotal showed that more than 50 security vendors classified the file as malicious. Further analysis identified the file as Flagpro malware. Related indicators included the domain `org.misecure.com`, IP address `207.148.109.242`, and MD5 hash `287d612e29b71c90aa54947313810a25`. Behavioral reporting also showed HTTP requests, input-capture activity, and command-and-control behavior.

Actions and Decisions

The file was classified as malicious based on the combined vendor detections and supporting behavioral evidence. Related indicators were documented so they could be used for additional investigation, detection, or threat hunting.

Next Steps / Escalation

The malicious file and associated indicators should be escalated for further investigation. Additional systems and logs should be searched for the identified hash, domain, IP address, and related activity to determine whether the malware exists elsewhere in the environment.

Additional Notes

This investigation demonstrates why a file hash alone is only a starting point. Correlating vendor detections with network indicators and behavioral evidence provides much stronger support for determining whether an artifact is malicious and understanding what activity may be associated with it.

Date	Entry #	Incident / Case ID	Severity	Status
October 8, 2026	3	SIM-IR-003	Medium	Escalated

Entry Title

Phishing Alert Triage and Escalation

Description

A phishing alert involving a suspicious email and executable attachment was reviewed using an incident response playbook. The message contained several phishing indicators, and the attached file hash had already been identified as malicious. Based on the available evidence, the alert was escalated for further investigation.

NIST Incident Response Phase

Detection and Analysis — The alert and supporting evidence were reviewed to determine whether the email represented a legitimate phishing threat. Email details, attachment information, and the known malicious file hash were evaluated before deciding how the alert should be handled.

Tool(s) and Data Sources Used

Tools: Incident response playbook and alert ticket

Data sources: Email headers and content, attachment information, known malicious file hash, and phishing alert details.

The 5 W's

- **Who:** An employee received a suspicious email appearing to come from “Clyde West” at Def Communications.
- **What:** The email attempted to persuade the recipient to download and open a password-protected executable attachment named `bfsvc.exe`.
- **When:** Wednesday, July 20, 2022 at approximately 9:30 a.m.
- **Where:** The phishing message was delivered to the organization’s HR email account.
- **Why / How:** The attacker used a job-related message and attachment to encourage the recipient to open a malicious file. Sender inconsistencies, grammar issues, the executable attachment, and its known malicious hash supported classification as a phishing attempt.

Evidence and Findings

The sender’s email address did not match the displayed identity or organization, and the message contained grammatical errors. The email included a password-protected executable attachment named `bfsvc.exe`. The attachment’s SHA-256 hash, `54e6ea47eb04634d3e87fd7787e2136ccfbcc80ade34f246a12cf93bab527f6b`, had already been identified as malicious. Together, these indicators supported the phishing determination.

Actions and Decisions

The alert was reviewed according to the incident response playbook and documented in ticket A-2703. Because the employee may have downloaded and opened a known malicious file, the ticket was classified as a legitimate phishing incident and escalated to a level-two SOC analyst for further investigation.

Next Steps / Escalation

Further investigation should determine whether the attachment executed successfully and whether the affected endpoint or account shows additional signs of compromise. Related email, endpoint, authentication, and network activity should be reviewed to determine the scope of the incident.

Additional Notes

This activity demonstrated that phishing triage relies on combining multiple indicators rather than judging an email from one suspicious feature alone. Sender inconsistencies, message quality, attachment type, and known malicious-file information collectively provided enough evidence to justify escalation.

Date	Entry #	Incident / Case ID	Severity	Status
October 9, 2026	4	SIM-IR-004	N/A	Analysis Complete

Entry Title

Suricata IDS Alert and Log Analysis

Description

Network traffic from a packet capture was analyzed with Suricata using a custom intrusion detection rule. The activity involved generating alerts from the captured traffic, reviewing Suricata log output, and filtering JSON event data to identify relevant network and alert information.

NIST Incident Response Phase

Detection and Analysis — Suricata was used to inspect captured network traffic and identify activity that matched a detection rule. Alert and event logs were then reviewed to understand the traffic and extract relevant details.

Tool(s) and Data Sources Used

Tools: Suricata, jq, Linux command line

Data sources: sample.pcap, custom.rules, fast.log, and eve.json

The 5 W's

- **Who:** The activity focused on network traffic rather than a specifically identified user or threat actor.
- **What:** Suricata analyzed packet-capture data and generated alerts when traffic matched the supplied custom rule.
- **When:** The activity did not provide a specific incident date or time.
- **Where:** Analysis was performed in a Linux environment using captured network traffic.
- **Why / How:** A custom Suricata rule was applied to the packet capture to identify matching HTTP traffic, after which the generated logs were examined for additional details.

Evidence and Findings

Suricata generated alert information in fast.log and more detailed JSON event data in eve.json. The first alert had a severity value of 3 and used the signature GET on WIRE. Using jq to extract selected fields made it possible to review timestamps, flow IDs, alert signatures, protocols, and destination IP addresses. The last reviewed event showed destination IP 142.250.1.102.

Actions and Decisions

The packet capture was processed with the supplied Suricata rule, and the resulting alerts were reviewed in both `fast.log` and `eve.json`. JSON output was filtered with `jq` to isolate useful fields and specific flow data, making the alert information easier to investigate.

Next Steps / Escalation

In a real investigation, matching alerts would be correlated with additional network, endpoint, and system logs to determine whether the detected traffic represented malicious activity or a false positive. Relevant flow IDs, IP addresses, and alert signatures could be used to guide further investigation.

Additional Notes

This activity showed the difference between generating an IDS alert and actually interpreting it. Suricata identified traffic that matched a rule, but the surrounding log data was still necessary to understand the event and decide whether further investigation would be warranted.